

Zuckerberg's AI-fuelled metamorphosis

We've all lived through Facebook's Cambridge Analytica data scandals, seen all the funny memes of their CEO, likening him to a humanoid bot devoid of all emotions. Despite suffering huge bodyblows, Mark Zuckerberg and Meta are still standing strong, aiming to pivot beyond just running the world's largest social media platforms.

The proof of this came in the launch of Meta's Llama 3.1 405B – which made history by becoming the world's largest open-source LLM till date with 405 billion parameters. Zuckerberg used the release of Llama 3.1 as an opportunity to share his two cents about AI in the form of an open letter. If you read the detailed manifesto outlined for Meta's future in artificial intelligence, central to this vision is Zuckerberg's belief in open-source AI as the driving force for future innovation and equitable access of AI for all human beings; where responsible AI development, prioritising safety and societal benefits come ahead of company and shareholder profits. Mark Zuckerberg's clearly shifting gears here or even tracks, jumping from one (social media) train to another (AI) bandwagon. But it begs two important and immediate questions: After pumping billions into their AI product development, that began as Facebook Artificial Intelligence Research (FAIR) over a decade ago, why is Zuckerberg offering and open-sourcing Meta AI's crown jewels for free? How will they make money, grow company value and keep shareholders happy?

Meta's decision to freely share its advanced Llama 3.1 (and Llama 3.0 earlier) language model stands in stark contrast to the subscription-based approach adopted by competitors. Imagine subscribers paying US \$20 for OpenAI's ChatGPT or Anthropic's Claude AI chatbots, and along comes Meta with its Llama 3.1 LLM which essentially gives anyone the capability to run their own version of ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini AI chatbots for free – with comparative or even better performance in terms of quality and efficiency. A shrewd move to slow down the competitive AI landscape and break the dominance of closed source foundational AI model



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based products and services, allowing Meta time to catch up and work on derivative products of their own open-sourced AI tech.

As per Zuckerberg's AI manifesto, Meta's strategy is clearly to accelerate its own AI progress by opening the technology to a broader community of developers. By doing so, Meta hopes to rapidly enhance its core systems – not just in the AI realm, but also its social media platforms – and outpace competitors in the long run. While the immediate financial implications might not make sense, Zuckerberg envisions a long-term strategy where owning a leading LLM can serve as a foundation for future revenue-generation. Does this move position Meta and Zuckerberg – as a pioneer in the open-source AI landscape, potentially shaping its future? Given the insanely rapid rate of progress of AI products, the only safe prediction about the future of AI is to not make any predictions, as one technology expert recently told me in a separate interview.

However, what's been truly revealing for me through this Meta AI manifesto is Mark Zuckerberg's concern for AI's ability to cause unintentional harm, “ranging from what influence AI systems will have on the billions of people who will use them to most of the truly catastrophic science fiction scenarios for humanity,” he writes. On this front, he argues, “open source should be significantly safer since the systems are more transparent and can be widely scrutinised. Historically, open source software has been more secure for this reason,” suggests Zuckerberg.

From the days of harvesting user data without consent, amplifying fake news, and facing global antitrust investigations, Zuckerberg's Meta has seen it all. Mark Zuckerberg, himself the quintessential Silicon Valley capitalist, who once embodied the very essence of profit-driven big tech, seems to have had an epiphany in the face of AI. He's willing to put aside short-term profits for long-term gains, embracing transparency and collaboration. What a journey it's been for Zuckerberg! Will this newfound benevolence lead to success? Only time will tell, but one can't help but marvel at this remarkable transformation **■**